



IV



JESUS

THE GOSPELS

STUDY GUIDE • 4 OF 5

who he is and what he taught

LUKE, MARK, MATTHEW AND JOHN

// START HERE

Welcome to Jesus

Welcome to Jesus. Over seven weeks we read the Gospels to meet him: his birth, his baptism and testing, his call of the first disciples, the Sermon on the Mount, two famous parables, a storm and a tomb, and the question “Who do you say that I am?” We read for what the text says, ask honest questions, and leave each week with one step to try. Whether you have followed Jesus for decades or are only curious, you are welcome here.

◆ 01 How a session works

90 MIN

The same rhythm every week, so the group can relax into it.

GATHER · 10 MIN

Follow up on last week's step. Did you do it?

READ · 10 MIN

Scripture read aloud, then notes.

DISCUSS · 35 MIN

Questions, not a lecture. Everyone speaks.

ACT · 15 MIN

One step, one outward habit, then prayer.

◆ 02 What you need

BRING

- ◆ A Bible in a translation you trust
- ◆ This guide and a pen
- ◆ Anything else

BETWEEN MEETINGS

- ◆ A few minutes a day with the passage
- ◆ One step to act on
- ◆ One person to tell

◆ 03 About the passages

This guide gives **references only** and does not print Bible text, so read from your own Bible. If you paste text into a page, use a public-domain translation such as the KJV or WEB. Old Testament references use Hebrew-Bible chapter and verse numbering; where an English Bible differs, the English reference is in parentheses. This guide has 7 sessions, in canon order, as part of a five-guide journey from Genesis to Revelation.

// THE FRAME

Our group

Small, steady and weekly. Fixing these early is what lets people open up.

SIZE

6-12

people. Small enough that everyone speaks.

RHYTHM

Weekly

same day, time and place.

SEASON

7

weeks with a steady membership, then regroup.

01 Details

DAY · TIME

Day, time

PLACE

Address or room

LEADER

Name

FACILITATOR
ROTATION

Who leads which weeks

SEASON

Start – end date

CHILDCARE /
FOOD

Plan

GROUP CHAT

Link or name

OPEN / CLOSED

Closed for the season

NEXT SEASON

When we regroup

02 Roster

#	NAME	CONTACT	PRAYER OR CARE NOTE
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			

// AGREED TOGETHER

Our ground rules

Write them, read them aloud in week one, and sign. Edit freely: these are starting points, not commandments.

- 1 Show up and stay for the whole season.
- 2 What is shared here stays here.
- 3 Everyone speaks; no one dominates.
- 4 We may challenge one another kindly, and we agree to be challenged.
- 5 Let Scripture lead; opinions come second.
- 6 Pray for each other between meetings.
- 7 Your own rule

PHRASES FOR CHALLENGING KINDLY

- ◆ "Can you say more about that?"
- ◆ "What does the text say?"
- ◆ "What would it cost you to do that?"
- ◆ Your own phrase

WHEN A RULE IS BROKEN

How we will handle it: who speaks to whom, and how soon.

◆ We agree

Initials and date.

NAME

INITIALS

DATE

// CHOOSE HOW YOU READ

Four ways to study a passage

This guide assigns a method to each session. Change it if your group prefers another.

METHOD 1

Inductive

- ◆ Observe: what does it say?
- ◆ Interpret: what does it mean?
- ◆ Apply: what does it ask of me?

Best for: close reading

METHOD 2

Discovery Bible Study

- ◆ What does it say?
- ◆ What does it say about God? About people?
- ◆ What will I obey?
- ◆ Whom will I tell?

Best for: groups new to the Bible

METHOD 3

Lectio divina

- ◆ Read: a short passage, slowly
- ◆ Meditate: one phrase
- ◆ Pray: respond to God
- ◆ Rest: be still, then share

Best for: prayerful, quieter weeks

METHOD 4

Short accountability

- ◆ Did I do what I said?
- ◆ What did I read this week?
- ◆ Where did I struggle?
- ◆ Whom did I tell or serve?

Best for: pairs, or the opening of any session

◆ Methods in this guide

This guide uses Discovery, Inductive, Lectio divina. Short accountability opens every session in the “Gather” step.

// 7 WEEKS

Our season at a glance

The arc is set; adjust as you go.

WEEK	PASSAGE	THEME	METHOD	LEADS
1	Luke 1-2 (focus: 1:26-38; 2:1-20)	The birth of Jesus	Lectio divina	Name
2	Luke 3:21-4:13	Baptized and tested	Inductive	Name
3	Mark 1:14-20	Follow me	Discovery	Name
4	Matthew 5-7 (focus: 5:1-16; 6:9-15; 7:24-29)	The Sermon on the Mount	Lectio divina	Name
5	Luke 10:25-37; 15:11-32	Two parables	Discovery	Name
6	Mark 4:35-41; John 11:1-44	A storm and a tomb	Inductive	Name
7	Mark 8:27-9:8	Who do you say that I am?	Discovery	Name

LAST WEEK OF THE SEASON

Celebrate, review what changed, and decide whether to continue, regroup or multiply. Each guide in this set continues the story in canon order, from Genesis to Revelation.

// SESSION 1 OF 7 · LECTIO DIVINA

The birth of Jesus

LUKE 1-2 (FOCUS: 1:26-38; 2:1-20) · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Welcome everyone. Read the ground rules aloud (page 4) and share names.

WARM-UP

Share a favorite birth or arrival story from your family.

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Luke 1-2 (focus: 1:26-38; 2:1-20) aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

LUKE 1-2 (FOCUS: 1:26-38; 2:1-20)

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What does Gabriel tell Mary (1:30-33), and how does she respond (1:34, 38)? Who hears the news first in 2:8-14, and what are they told?

- 2 **INTERPRET** Why might the news come to a young woman and to shepherds and not to rulers? What do the angels call this news (2:10-11)?

- 3 **APPLY** Mary says yes without seeing everything ahead (1:38). Where is God asking you for a similar yes?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Christians read these chapters in different ways, including how to understand Mary and the details of the birth. What do we find in the text, and how do we stay kind where traditions differ?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Set aside ten minutes daily to read one of the Gospel birth accounts slowly, and tell your partner what you notice.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Give gifts or time to a family who is overlooked, such as a shelter or a refugee family.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Luke 1:46-55
(Mary's song).

DAY 2

Write your "yes" and
your fear.

DAY 3

Pray Mary's response in
your own words.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 2 OF 7 · INDUCTIVE

Baptized and tested

LUKE 3:21-4:13 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What helps you resist when you are tired or hungry?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Luke 3:21-4:13 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

LUKE 3:21-4:13

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What does the voice say at the baptism (3:21-22)? What are the three tests, and how does Jesus answer each (4:1-13)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** Jesus answers from Scripture (Deuteronomy 8:3; 6:13; 6:16). What do the tests have in common, and what do his answers say about trust and worship?

- 3 **APPLY** Which test (comfort, proving yourself, power) most tempts you? What Scripture could you keep ready?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Christians understand Jesus' baptism and the devil in different ways. How do we discuss differing ideas without losing the point of the passage?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Memorize one verse (for example from Deuteronomy 6 or 8) to use when tempted, and tell your partner.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Offer hospitality or help to someone struggling with an addiction or a hard season.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Luke 4:1-13.

DAY 2

Write which test is yours.

DAY 3

Pray the verse you chose.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 3 OF 7 • DISCOVERY

Follow me

MARK 1:14-20 • LEADS: NAME DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What is the best invitation you ever accepted?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Mark 1:14-20 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

MARK 1:14-20

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- OBSERVE** What does Jesus proclaim (1:14-15)? What does he say to Simon and Andrew, and James and John, and how do they respond (1:16-20)?

- INTERPRET** What does it mean to “follow” and to become people who fish for people? Why might they leave so quickly?

- APPLY** What would following Jesus ask you to leave, or to start, this season?

- CHALLENGE KINDLY** Following costs different things for different people. How can we encourage one another without comparing?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

What will I obey? Name one thing you will leave or begin as part of following Jesus. Whom will I tell?

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Invite a friend to something that matters to you, such as a meal or a service.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Mark 1:14-20.

DAY 2

Write what you would have to leave.

DAY 3

Pray “follow me” and listen.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 4 OF 7 · LECTIO DIVINA

The Sermon on the Mount

MATTHEW 5-7 (FOCUS: 5:1-16; 6:9-15; 7:24-29) · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Who has shown you what humility looks like?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Matthew 5-7 (focus: 5:1-16; 6:9-15; 7:24-29) aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

MATTHEW 5-7 (FOCUS: 5:1-16; 6:9-15; 7:24-29)

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 **OBSERVE** Who does Jesus call blessed in 5:3-12? What does he say about salt and light (5:13-16)?

2 **INTERPRET** What picture of God's kingdom emerges? What does the house on rock versus sand (7:24-27) say about hearing and doing?

3 **APPLY** Which Beatitude describes you now? Which is hardest to live out, and what would it look like?

4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** How do we avoid reading the Beatitudes as only a checklist or only comfort? Where do we need both comfort and challenge?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Choose one saying of Jesus to practice daily this week and report back.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Practice mercy: bring practical help to someone who is grieving or poor in spirit.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Matthew 5:1-12.

DAY 2

Write one Beatitude in your own words.

DAY 3

Pray Matthew 6:9-13 slowly.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 5 OF 7 • DISCOVERY

Two parables

LUKE 10:25-37; 15:11-32 • LEADS: NAME • DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Who is an unexpected person who helped you?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Luke 10:25-37; 15:11-32 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

LUKE 10:25-37; 15:11-32

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** Who stops and who passes by in 10:30-35? What does the younger son do, and what does the father do (15:17-24)? How does the elder brother react (15:25-30)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** Jesus turns "Who is my neighbor?" (10:29) into "Who proved a neighbor?" (10:36). Why? Why does the second parable end without telling us what the elder son does?

- 3 **APPLY** Which character are you today: the one who passes, the helper, the younger son or the elder son? Why?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Who is the "Samaritan" for us, someone we would rather not learn from? How can we look honestly at our own prejudices?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

What will I obey? Do one act of mercy for someone you would normally pass. Whom will I tell?

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Welcome someone who has drifted from church or family: reach out with a note or an invitation.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Luke 15:11-32.

DAY 2

Write which character you are like.

DAY 3

Pray for someone who has left.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 6 OF 7 · INDUCTIVE

A storm and a tomb

MARK 4:35-41; JOHN 11:1-44 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Describe a time you panicked, or a time you grieved.

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Mark 4:35-41; John 11:1-44 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

MARK 4:35-41; JOHN 11:1-44

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- OBSERVE** What do the disciples say and what does Jesus do in the storm (Mark 4:38-41)? What do Martha and Mary each say to Jesus, and what does he do (John 11:21-27, 11:32-44)?

- INTERPRET** What do the disciples ask in Mark 4:41? What does Jesus say about himself in John 11:25? Why does he weep (11:35) if he knows what he will do?

- APPLY** What storm or delay are you in? How might you bring it to Jesus with the honesty of Martha and Mary?

- CHALLENGE KINDLY** Miracle stories are hard for people whose prayers were not answered the way they asked. How do we honor both the texts and real experiences of unanswered prayer?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Bring one need to God daily this week and ask the group to pray for it. Reach out to someone grieving with presence, not answers.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Visit someone who is sick or grieving, and sit with them.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read John 11:17-27.

DAY 2

Write what you grieve.

DAY 3

Pray "Jesus wept" as a comfort.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 7 OF 7 · DISCOVERY

Who do you say that I am?

MARK 8:27-9:8 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Who do people say you are, and who are you?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Mark 8:27-9:8 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

MARK 8:27-9:8

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What two questions does Jesus ask (8:27, 8:29)? What does Peter answer, and what does Jesus say next (8:29-33)? What happens on the mountain (9:2-8)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** Why does Jesus describe suffering and rejection (8:31) and then rebuke Peter (8:33)? What does it mean to "take up the cross" (8:34), and what does the voice say in 9:7?

- 3 **APPLY** How would you answer Jesus' question today, in your own words? What does following him cost or give?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** People hold many views about who Jesus is. How can we speak honestly about our own view while welcoming people at different places in their questions?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

What will I obey? Write your own answer to "Who do you say that I am?" and share it. Plan what you will do after the season ends. Whom will I tell?

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Share your answer with a friend outside the group if appropriate, or pray for a friend who is exploring faith.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Mark 8:27-38.

DAY 2

Write your answer.

DAY 3

Pray for those who are exploring.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// PERSONAL REFLECTION

Five days, five short moments

The strongest measured predictor of spiritual growth is reading and reflecting on your own between meetings. Ten minutes is enough. Use the passage from your next session.

◆ 01 Read

10 MIN

Read the week's passage slowly, once. Note the reference.

◆ 02 Notice

10 MIN

Write one line: what stands out?

◆ 03 Ask

10 MIN

Write one question you would ask God about it.

◆ 04 Do

10 MIN

Take this week's step. What happened?

◆ 05 Pray

10 MIN

Pray for the person or place outside the group.

BRING TO NEXT SESSION

One thing you noticed, one question, one result from your step.

// TOGETHER AND BEYOND

Prayer requests

NAME	REQUEST	DATE	ANSWERED

◆ Beyond the group

An outward-facing habit keeps the group from turning inward: people and places we pray for or serve outside the circle.

WHO OR WHERE	PRAY / SERVE	WHEN	DONE

◆ Season project (optional)

One thing we do together for others.

Share a meal each month with someone who is lonely, and invite friends who are curious about Jesus to join you.

Project, date, who is leading · Your plan

// FOR THE LEADER

Leader's notes

The leader guides; the group discovers. Ask, listen, and resist teaching the whole passage.

BEFORE

- ◆ Read the passage twice and note your own questions
- ◆ Pick the method and rehearse the four questions
- ◆ Pray for each person by name

AFTER

- ◆ Text a note to anyone who was quiet
- ◆ Log the steps people named
- ◆ Your own follow-up

◆ 01 Timing guide

90 MIN

PART	MIN	NOTES
Gather & follow up	10	<u>Notes</u>
Open in prayer	3	<u>Notes</u>
Read	10	<u>Notes</u>
Discuss	35	<u>Notes</u>
This week's step	10	<u>Notes</u>
Beyond the group · prayer	12	<u>Notes</u>
Buffer	10	<u>Notes</u>

◆ 02 Hard moments in this guide

DOUBT ABOUT MIRACLES

Some members find miracle stories hard to believe, and others have prayed for healing that did not come. Make room for honesty; never imply that faith guarantees healing.

PARABLES THAT CONFRONT

Jesus' stories can feel uncomfortable. Allow silence and avoid rushing to comfort.

SEEKERS IN THE ROOM

Invite questions from people who are exploring, and do not pressure anyone to state a belief.

◆ 03 Session notes

WHY THIS STRUCTURE

Groups reliably build belonging and forgiveness, but showing up does not by itself deepen Bible knowledge or growth. The design leans on discussion, written ground rules, a step to act on, personal reflection between meetings and an outward habit. The 6-12 size and 8-12 week season are practitioner advice, not a measured result.

// SESSION BY SESSION

What to watch for

A short note for each week. Edit freely.

WEEK	PASSAGE	WATCH FOR
1	Luke 1–2 (focus: 1:26–38; 2:1–20)	Christians agree on the central claims but traditions differ on details (for example the role of Mary). Stay with the text and avoid debate.
2	Luke 3:21–4:13	Addiction and shame may come up; do not probe. Keep to what the text says.
3	Mark 1:14–20	Avoid guilt about job or family. Frame “leaving” as priorities, not only dramatic change.
4	Matthew 5–7 (focus: 5:1–16; 6:9–15; 7:24–29)	Some will ask how literally to take the sermon. Stay with what Jesus says and invite honest wrestling.
5	Luke 10:25–37; 15:11–32	Parables can hit uncomfortably. Allow silence and avoid rushing to comfort.
6	Mark 4:35–41; John 11:1–44	Be pastorally careful about illness and loss, and never imply faith guarantees healing. Grief may surface, so keep tissues, allow quiet, and follow up privately.
7	Mark 8:27–9:8	The group may include seekers; let them ask without pressure. Use this last session to review the season and plan what is next.